LESSON 7

Frère Jacques

An old French round about Brother John, who sleeps through the morning bells. Sing it as a round: a second voice starts two bars later.

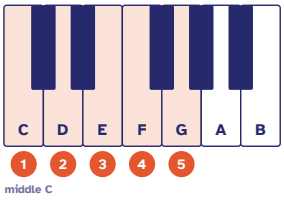
LISTEN FIRST
Scan the code: listen once, then hum along.

THE WOW MOMENT
Din, dan, don: the left hand rings the bells, low C, G, C. Then play it as a **round** with a friend: two tunes at once make harmony.

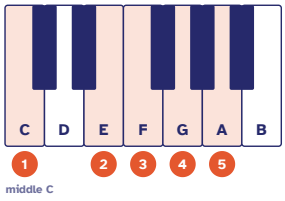
1 Meet the song

Listen, pointing to each note. Sing it in French, then play the tune with the right hand, then as a round with a friend: the second player starts two bars later.

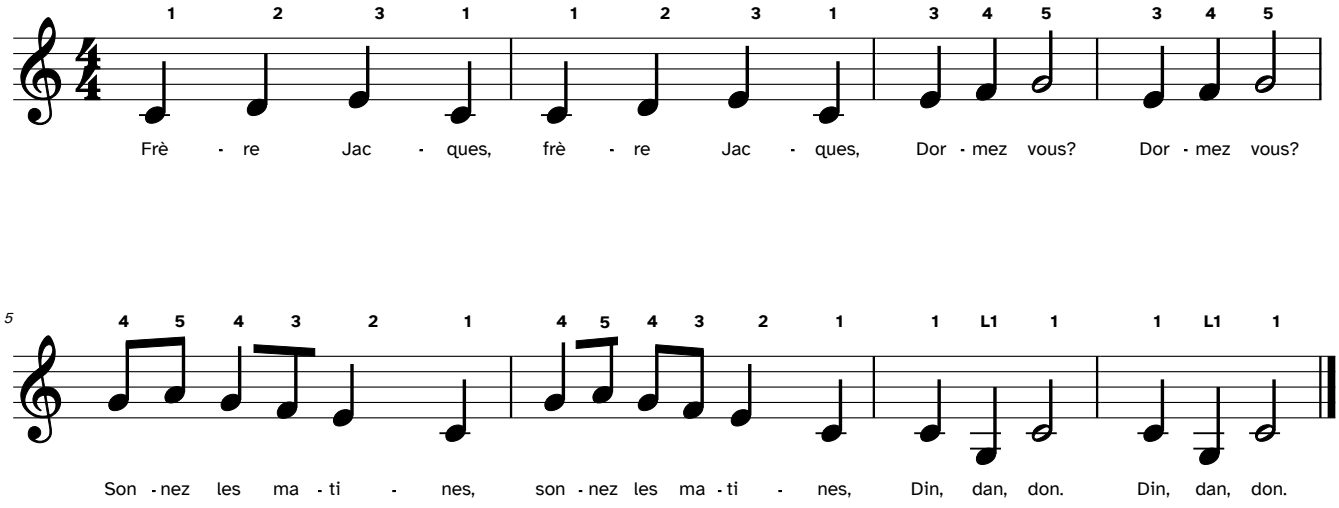
LINES 1–2 · C POSITION



LINE 3 · THE HAND OPENS



Right hand, lines 1–2: the C position, 1 2 3 4 5 from middle C to G. **Line 3:** the hand opens; the thumb stays on C, so G A G F E C is 4 5 4 3 2 1.
L: the low G in *din, dan, don* is the left hand's. Both hands meet on page 3.



☐ Listened and pointed ☐ Played the tune ☐ Played it as a round

2 Take it apart

The same song, one piece at a time: first its rhythm, then its notes.

NEW IN THIS SONG

The root. The left hand plays low C at the start of every bar and holds it. C is the home note the whole song stands on: its **root**. Letters now sit only on the first note of each line.

THE RHYTHM

Say the words in time, then clap them and count: clap on the coral numbers, hold through the grey ones.

THE TIME

4/4

Top 4: four beats in every bar.

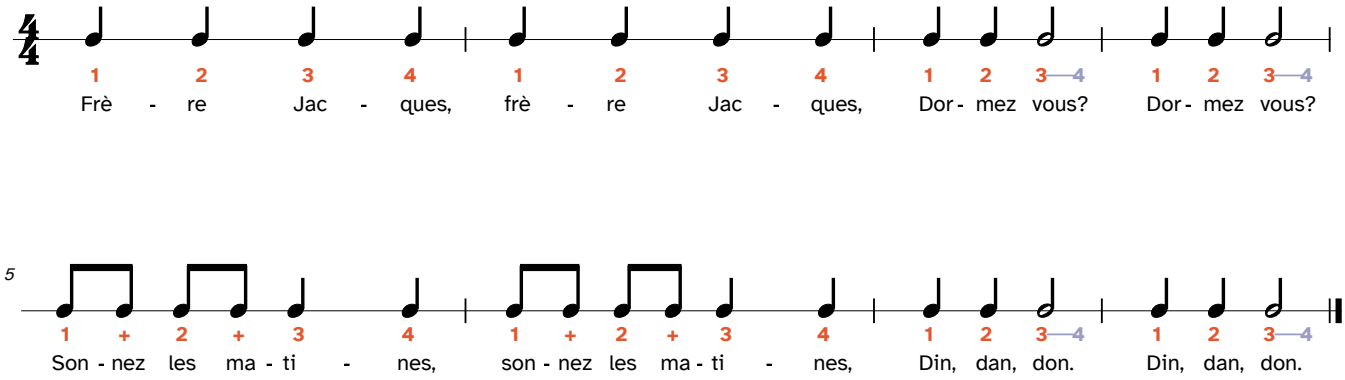
Bottom 4: a crotchet is one beat.

THE NOTES

crotchet: walk — 1 beat

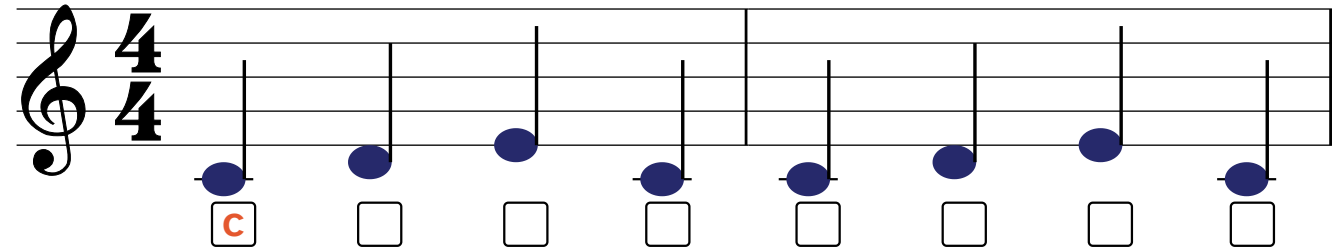
two quavers: run-ning — 1 beat

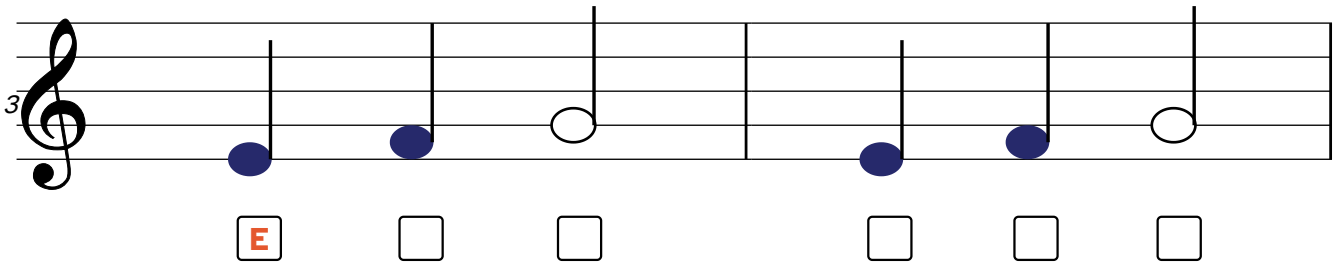
minim: hold — 2 beats



THE NOTES

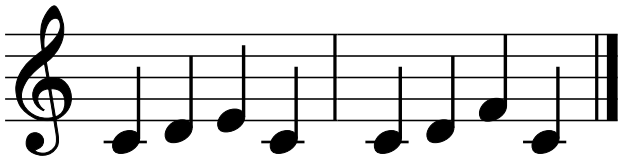
Only the first note of each line keeps its letter now. Write the others: count up or down from the one given.





SPOT THE MISTAKE

One note here is wrong. Play it, then the same bars on page 1: which note sounds wrong? Circle it.



- [ ] **Said it in time**
- [ ] **Clapped and counted**
- [ ] **Wrote the letter names**
- [ ] **Spotted the mistake**

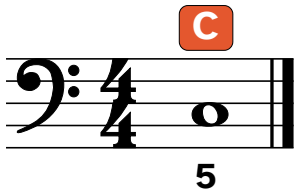
3 Lead sheet

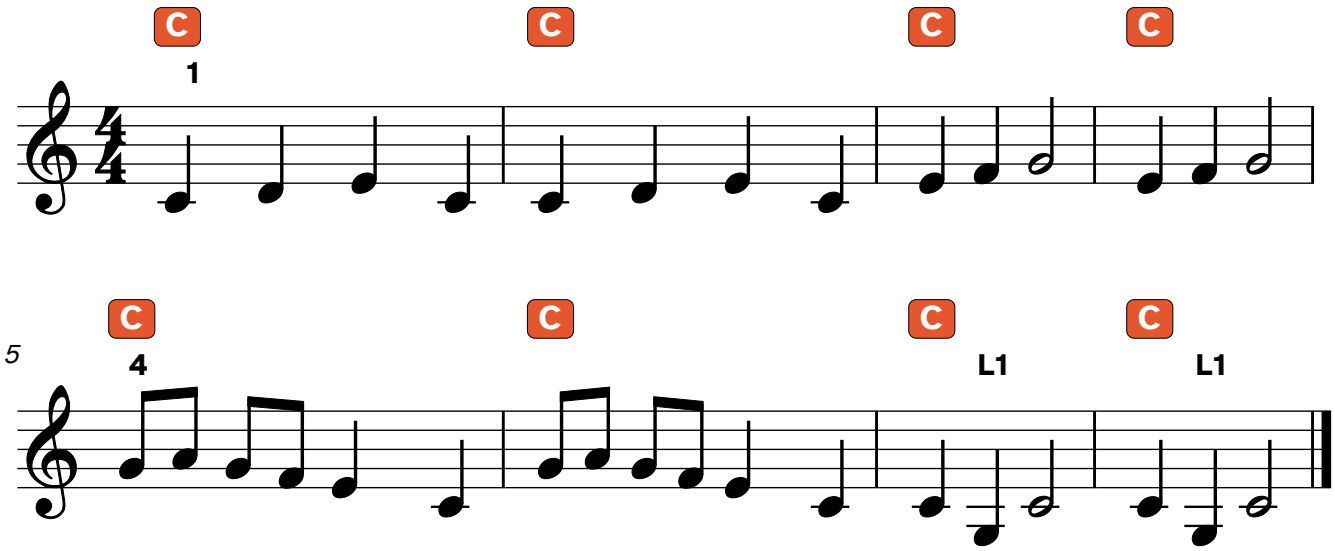
Your first accompaniment pattern. The whole song is one chord, C: the left hand holds low C under every bar. In bars 7 and 8 the left hand plays dang (G) instead.

PATTERN 1 · THE ROOT, HELD

Play the root on beat 1 and hold it through the bar, all four beats. Frère Jacques needs only C.

C





1 Tune alone, right hand

2 Pattern alone: hold C, count four

3 Together, slowly

4 · CHECK

☐ I can say and clap it ☐ I can play it as a round

I can play it: colour a step each time you climb

	With letters	No letters	With the band	Fast
The tune				
With the pattern				

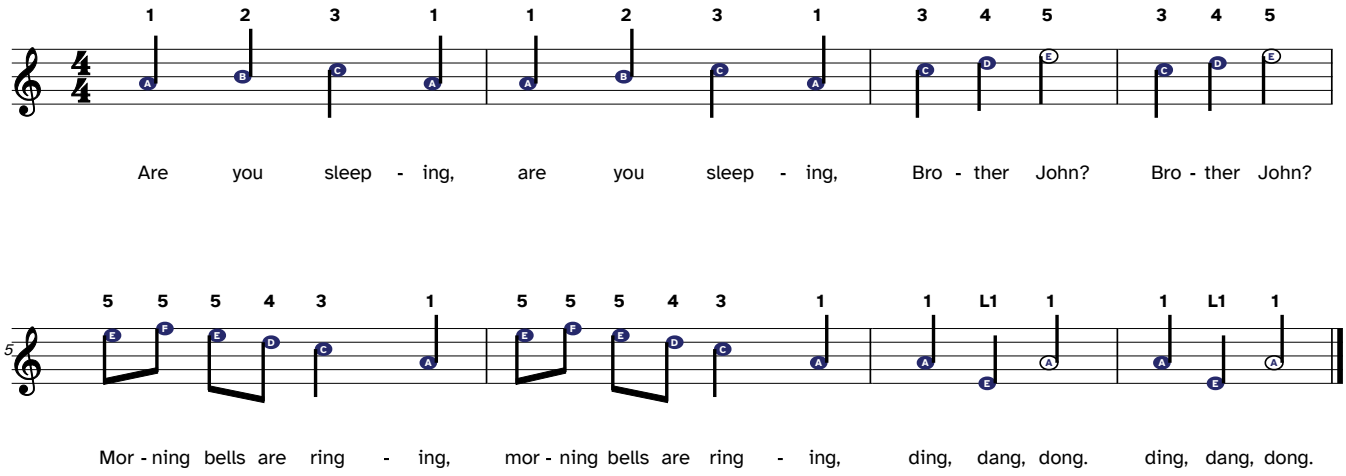
LISTEN BACK ☐ I recorded it ☐ It sounded right

+ More to play

The same song by night, the way Mahler heard it; then a slow walk for the left hand, a peek at Lesson 8.

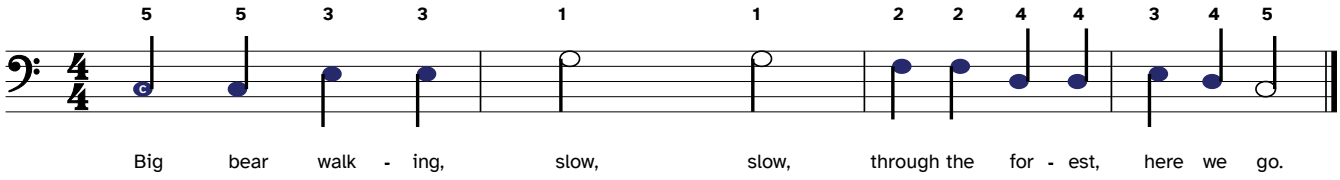
BROTHER JOHN AT NIGHT

Mahler put this song in his First Symphony as a slow, dark march. The trick: start on A instead of C, the same hand shape, and the song turns minor. Passport stamp: Mahler.



BEAR WALK

Slow and heavy, a peek at Lesson 8: the left hand plays the tune, low on the King's staff.



MAKE IT YOURS

Pick one and play the whole song that way.

Record it on a phone and listen back: does it sound the way you meant?

- ☐ **Sleepy: slow, soft and smooth**
- ☐ **Bouncy: short and light, like a ball**
- ☐ **By night: start on A, the same shape, and hear it turn minor**

5 MINUTES AT HOME

1. Listen to the song once
2. The tune, right hand
3. Pattern 1 under the tune (page 3)
4. Play it with the band

☐ M ☐ T ☐ W ☐ T ☐ F ☐ S ☐ S

☐ **Played Brother John at Night** ☐ **Played Bear Walk**